



Mixed Moods

Grade 3

Acrylic Paint



Los Altos School District · 201 Covington Road · Los Altos · CA · 94024 · 650.947.1195

www.losaltosartdocents.org

Revised: June 2024

MIXED MOODS

Length: 75 minutes

Number of docents: 2

Purpose: Explore color through observation of fine art and by creating tints, tones and shades to use in students' original artwork.

Visual Arts Standards:

- Elaborate on an imaginative idea. (3.VA:Cr1.1)
- Apply knowledge of available resources, tools, and technologies to investigate personal ideas through the art-making process. (3.VA:Cr1.2)
- Create personally satisfying artwork using a variety of artistic processes and materials. (3.VA:Cr2.1)
- Demonstrate an understanding of the safe and proficient use of materials, tools, and equipment for a variety of artistic processes. (3.VA:Cr2.2)
- Discuss, reflect, and add details to enhance an artwork's emerging meaning. (3.VA:Cr3)
- Determine messages communicated by an image. (3.VA:Re7.2)
- Interpret art by analyzing use of media to create subject matter, characteristics of form, and mood. (3.VA:Re8)
- Evaluate an artwork based on given criteria. (3.VA:Re9)

Unit Contains:

- Supply box
- Portfolio

Materials docent will bring:

- Acrylic paint- white, black, red, yellow, blue, green, and purple
- Paper plates
- Paint brushes – one large and one small per student
- 10" x 8" Acrylic paper
- Popsicle stick
- Water containers
- Brush Cleaner and Preserver

Materials teacher will provide:

- Paper towels
- Pencils

- 18" x 12" Newsprint to cover desks

Featured works:

First Steps (after Millet) (1890)

Vincent Van Gogh

The First Steps (c. 1858-1866)

Jean-Francois Millet

The Fog Warning (1885)

Winslow Homer

Senecio (Head of a Man Going Senile) (1922)

Paul Klee

Vocabulary:

Color - produced when light strikes an object and is reflected back to the eye

Hue - the name of a color (red, yellow, blue, etc.)

Value - the lightness or darkness of a color

Tint - hue + white

Shade - hue + black

Tone - hue + gray

ROOM SET UP: Teacher has been asked to clear the students' desks. Docents will arrive in the classroom 20 minutes early to set up.

- Docent will write their name and assistant's names on the whiteboard.
- Have the posters facing the whiteboard before the lesson and then turn them around when you are ready for discussion.
- Docent will pass out white paper, newsprint, paper towel, and brush to every student. Use one half-full water container per grouping of students.
- Use photo or the paper template in the unit to set up students' palettes. Depending on space, Docent can put the paint palette with only the black and white paint on desks (colors can be added later), or the palettes can be placed on a back table and the students can line up to pick out their palette and color when instructed.
- Docent will use whiteboard to create sample of geometric drawings.
- Docent will show samples from the portfolio before the students create their drawings



INTRODUCTION (20 Minutes):

Ask students to sit on carpet to discuss the prints and for demonstration away from desks/supplies if possible.

Today's lesson is all about the art element color.

ART ELEMENTS

LINE:
 Direction: horizontal vertical diagonal
 Quality: Curvy, straight,
Thick, Thin

SHAPE: Geometric, Organic

TEXTURE: ROUGH, Smooth, etc.

COLOR: **HUE, PRIMARY, SECONDARY,**
 Complementary pairs,
WARM or **COOL**, **VALUE**

SPACE: **POSITIVE** (filled) &
NEGATIVE (unfilled),
 Perspective/Depth (fore, middle)

Art elements are the tools an artist uses to tell a story. Let's review them so we can use these vocabulary words when observing the artwork we see today.

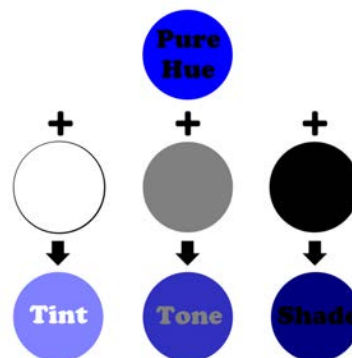
What we will explore today is "value."

What is value? (the lightness or darkness of a color)

How do you create a light value? A dark value?

- Tint = hue + white
- Shade = hue + black
- Tone = hue + gray

As you go, you can write answers on the board for students to reference during lesson or you can use the Painters' Color Mixing poster.



The name of our lesson is "Mixed Moods". We will be looking at some famous paintings and how artists use value to create mood, show weather effects, time of day or seasons in their work. Then we will create our own artwork where we will experiment creating our own tints, shades and tones.

FIRST STEPS (c. 1858-1866)

Jean-Francois Millet

Black and white reproduction



Raise your hand if you have heard of Vincent Van Gogh.

When Van Gogh was living in the countryside his brother Theo sent black and white drawings or photographs to keep him updated on what artists were doing in Paris. He sent Van Gogh one of Millet's drawing similar to this.

Van Gogh pays tribute to Millet by using this scene and exploring the use of color using oil paints to create his own work of art. Close your eyes and picture what colors Van Gogh might choose.

FIRST STEPS, 1890

Vincent Van Gogh

Oil on canvas

29" x 36"



What hues do you see in this painting? Tints? Shades?

What is happening in this picture? (It is called First Steps)

What is the mood of this painting? Use one "emotion word" to describe your feelings (happy, sad, etc)

Close your eyes and imagine if Van Gogh had decided to use shades instead of tints. How would the mood of the *First Steps* change? Would you change the name of the painting?

***THE FOG WARNING* (1885)**

Winslow Homer

Oil on canvas

30" x 48"



Suggested Dialog:

What hues do you see in this painting? Tones? Shades?

What is happening in this painting? (Fisherman is rowing to get back to his ship in stormy weather)

What is the mood of this painting? What about the picture do you think makes you feel the way you do when you look at it? (Dark shades are gloomy)

Close your eyes and imagine if Homer decided to use tints instead of shades.

How would the mood of *The Fog Warning* change? Would you change the name of the painting?

***SENECIO (HEAD OF A MAN GOING SENILE)* (1922)**

Paul Klee

Oil on canvas

16" x 15"



Make the expression on this person's face. Describe how you feel when you have that expression on your face? (confused, puzzled)

Note for docent: The alternate name for this painting is Head of a Man Going Senile. Senile is a term used when someone older has problems remembering things or is easily confused.

What colors do you see? Tints? Tones? Shades? (red, yellow, orange)

What geometric shapes do you see? (circle, rectangle, square, triangle, etc)

Today we are going to pay homage to the artist Paul Klee by using his painting *Senecio* as an inspiration for our Tints and Shades Experiments.

DEMONSTRATION (2 minutes): While the children are still at the front of the room, demonstrate drawing on the whiteboard.

What types of shapes and lines could we use to create this person?

- Oval, circle
- Rectangle, square, polygon
- Parallel lines, intersecting lines

On your desk you will find a piece of white paper and you are going to create your own geometric head drawing using an oval, two rectangles and some additional lines to suggest facial features.

1. Put a dot near the top of the paper and another dot about 2/3 down the paper → draw a circle between the two dots to create the head.
2. Add neck and shoulders (rectangles)
3. Add eyes and use lines and geometric shapes to create nose, mouth and other facial features.

Tips:

- Do not draw too small
- Show the brush size and encourage students to create large areas to be painted
- Head can be oval, circle, etc
- Add straight lines, curvy lines, intersecting lines
- Post samples from portfolio as the students begin to draw

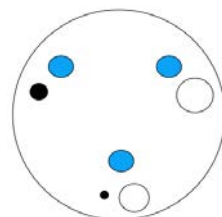
Dismiss students to their desks and provide 3-5 minute for students to draw.

Next step- color mixing: Your next decision is what color will you choose. Think about how the color will affect the mood of the painting.

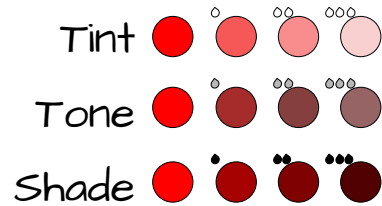
On your table you will find a paper plate palette to which your chosen hue will be added by a docent, along with white and black to create tints and shades. You will use these at least 6 tints, tones and shades from the same hue to fill in the geometric spaces on your face.

The palette is set up to help you create your new values. Your goal is to have 10 or more tints, tones and shades in your artwork.

1. Select an area to use the pure hue



2. Begin mixing a tiny bit of the hue to the white → paint a selection with that tint → repeat → repeat
3. Begin mixing a tiny bit of black to the hue → paint a selection with that shade → repeat → repeat
4. Mix a bit of the black with the white and add a bit of the hue → paint a selection with that tone → repeat → repeat



Plan ahead:

- Push up your sleeves
- Start with the hue add white/black/grey
- Use a popsicle stick to mix your paint
- Plan on using 6-7 different values
- Background color is ok after your head and shoulders are complete
- If necessary, remove paint by gently swishing in water, then DRY off brush on paper towel.
- When you are not using your brush, keep it in the water then blot on the paper towel before dipping in paint again.
- Use gentle strokes when you paint.



REFLECTION: (5 minutes)

As students finish their work they should clean up but leave their artwork on their desk. Ask the students to be prepared to tell the class what is the mood of the painting and the title painting.

Depending on the class, this can be done:

- In table groups as the class is still working
- Calling for silent work time for the last 5 minutes and having students go to the front of the class to present
- If time allows, having students clean up first and then present to class

CLEAN-UP

Acrylic Brush Care

Acrylic paint brushes require extra care as the paint sticks in the bristles and ferrule more than watercolor! Please plan to spend time cleaning the brushes:

1. Wash out excess paint in warm water
2. Lather with soap or brush cleaner and preserver
3. In the palm of hand, gently rub bristle on side to pull out additional paint
4. Squeeze out suds and paint
5. Rinse
6. Repeat until water runs clear
7. Squeeze out excess water and reshape bristles

8. If the brush tip isn't pointy, you can shape with brush cleaner and leave it on to dry to help form the point
9. Lay flat to dry in bamboo rolling mat

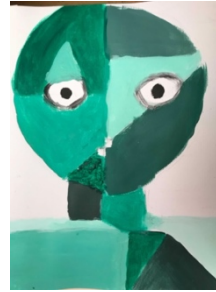
Parent Instructions for Mixed Moods

Thank you for volunteering today!

Please help by:

Setting up lesson supplies

- Clear desks/tables
- Place newsprint down to protect desks
- Pass out canvas paper with Art Docent stamp side up, paper towel, 2 brushes and wooden stick
- Place one water container to share at each group
- Prepare paint palettes with black and white paint as pictured



During the lesson

- Listen carefully to the docent instructions to the students
- Assist individual students by walking around the room
- Add three blobs of the student's choice of color as pictured
- Refill paints if needed
- Encourage students to mix 10 or more tints, tones, and shades

Additional tips

- Please don't work on students' art — demonstrate on scrap materials
- Ask Art Docents if a student needs extra help
- Have fun!

Helping clean-up

- Clean brushes thoroughly by washing out excess paint in water, lather with soap, and gently rub bristles to remove extra paint. Rinse and repeat until the water runs clear.
- Paper plates are disposable
- Wipe down tables

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BACKGROUND

VINCENT VAN GOGH 1853-1890

Vincent was named after his grandfather and a stillborn brother exactly one year older. During his mostly unhappy childhood in the Dutch Reformed religious home of his pastor father, he felt that he was a replacement for someone else. The extended van Gogh family gravitated to either art or religious occupations but Vincent's highly strung and sensitive temperament made many people avoid him. His one great ally from early times was his younger brother, Theo (1857-1891); as teenagers they made a pact, swearing never to desert each other. Theo and Vincent wrote on an almost daily basis and these letters give us an exceptionally important insight into Vincent's anxious personality and his thoughts about painting. The brothers are buried next to each other in Auvers-sur-Oise, France.

The ardent personality and intense emotions of van Gogh are visible in the way he painted—color is a vehicle for the artist's expression rather than to define the object. The paint is laid down in streaks and ridges of impasto, speaking to the quickness of the brushstrokes and the intensity of the artist's emotional vision.

The First Steps (after Millet), 1890

Oil on canvas

28 x 35 7/8 inches

Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York

In May of 1889 Vincent's mental problems required treatment in the asylum at Saint- Rémy in the south of France. Limited in his access to the world outside the asylum, he became interested in the work of other artists. Theo would often send him black and white photos and prints and Vincent especially enjoyed copying Delacroix, Rembrandt and Millet. He referred to the copying as "interpretations" or "improvisations" as musicians would play the works of composers. "I pose the black and white [prints] of Millet before me as a subject and improvise color on it...it is my interpretation," he wrote to Theo.

Millet's work appealed to van Gogh because both artists felt a kinship with the peasant as the last untouched, most "pure" of human beings. He painted *First Steps* in January of 1890 when he heard the news that Theo was soon to be a father. "Ah, now certainly you are yourself deep in nature, since you say that Jo (Theo's wife) already feels her child quicken...How beautiful that Millet is, *The First Steps of a Child*."

WINSLOW HOMER 1836-1910 (American)

Homer was basically a self-taught artist with professional training in commercial lithography. His first job was a “visual journalist” for *Harper’s Weekly* during the Civil War years, 1863-65. After the war he concentrated on the secure, idealized life of American children.

A year spent in England, 1881-82, where he painted the environment and fishing families in Cullercoats, changed the direction of his art—the sea became his favorite subject and his style more monumental. In 1883 he closed his New York studio and moved permanently to Prout’s Neck, Maine, although he continued both foreign and domestic travel. Homer loved solitude and tried to avoid as many people as possible. Barbara Novak noted that his main artistic concern was “with the obdurate and obstinate, with survival in the face of elemental dangers.”

Fog Warning, 1885

Oil on canvas

30 x 48 inches

Museum of Fine Arts, Boston

This painting was first called *Halibut Fishing*, and shows the hazards and hardships of work in the Newfoundland Banks. The drop-line used to catch halibut can be seen behind the fisherman and near the catch is his fresh-water keg. A contemporary writer described the work thus, “Even in Summer, the men who go out in their dories...are frequently overtaken by the dense fogs so prevalent on the banks. Losing the position of their floating headquarters, the schooner, they drift hopelessly about, falling prey to hunger and thirst, until...they may reach land, or exhausted and emaciated, be picked up by some passing vessel. ...too often are these brave fellows overwhelmed by the force of nature’s elements, and borne down forever to a billowy grave, their lonely fate witnessed only by screaming gulls.”

Revision History

Revision Date	Docent Name	Comments
Spring 2018	Kristine Bardman led committee	As part of the 5-year plan, emphasis was placed on art element of color (value). Select prints from the “Exploring Color” lesson were added to enhance the discussion and introduction.
May 2019	Kristine Bardman	Instructions more defined, new CA VAPA standards added
December 2019	Kimberly Dickerson	Brush cleaning instructions added
October 2022	Kimberly Dickerson and Ann Kanodia	Updated brush care and added new poster
November 2023	Kimberly Dickerson	Updated brush care
June 2024	Curriculum Committee	Parent Volunteer Instructions Added
January 2025	Kimberly Dickerson	Brush Cleaner and Preserver added